

2 Subject content

Qualification aims and objectives

The aims and objectives of this qualification are to enable students to:

- develop and extend their knowledge and understanding of specified key events, periods and societies in local, British, and wider world history; and of the wide diversity of human experience
- engage in historical enquiry to develop as independent learners and as critical and reflective thinkers
- develop the ability to ask relevant questions about the past, to investigate issues critically and to make valid historical claims by using a range of sources in their historical context
- develop an awareness of why people, events and developments have been accorded historical significance and how and why different interpretations have been constructed about them
- organise and communicate their historical knowledge and understanding in different ways and reach substantiated conclusions.

Summary of Department for Education content requirements

This GCSE complies with the requirements specified by the Department for Education (DfE) in its document *History GCSE subject content* (published April 2014). This requires students to study, as a minimum:

- two **depth studies**, each covering a substantial and short time span:
 - one must be a British depth study from the medieval (500–1500), early modern (1450–1700) or modern (1750–present) eras
 - the other must be a **European or wider-world depth study** from an era different to the British depth study
- a **period study** of at least 50 years from any of the eras
- the **historic environment** through the study of a particular site in its historical context
- a **thematic study** involving the study of people, events and developments drawn from all three eras defined above.

The DfE also requires that British history must form at least 40% of the assessed content.

Creating a coherent and substantial course of study

The DfE's *History GCSE subject content* (April 2014) requires that GCSE History qualifications 'must provide a coherent and substantial course of study'.

Pearson has provided options in this specification that, in combination, will enable centres to create courses that are coherent and substantial. It is important that centres are clear about how their chosen combinations of options meet this requirement. Further information about different approaches to this can be found in *Appendix 2*.

How content is expressed

Centres should refer to Appendix 3, which provides guidance about how to interpret the requirements and expectations around what is taught in the topics.

Entry codes

The tables in *Appendix 1* show the entry codes that must be used for a centre's chosen options.

Paper 1: Thematic study and historic environment

Overview

The relevant pages of this section specify the content that must be taught for the chosen option. All of the content for the option is mandatory.

Each Paper 1 option is divided into two: a thematic study and a linked study of a historic environment. This linked structure promotes topic coherence across Paper 1 and aids teaching and learning by allowing the issues studied in the historic environment to be seen within a broader thematic context.

Both parts cover British history.

Thematic studies

The thematic studies require students to understand change and continuity across a long sweep of history, including the most significant characteristics of different ages from the medieval to modern periods. They include people, events and developments and reveal wider changes in aspects of society over the centuries and allow comparisons to be made between different periods of history.

Each thematic study begins with an introductory section called *The process of change*. This explains the focus and identifies the relevant concepts and factors that need to be understood and applied when teaching the content.

This content is then divided into four further sections, which run sequentially from medieval to the present day. The four sections provide a framework for understanding the option, but should not be taken in isolation from each other – students should appreciate developments across the option as a whole. Each section is divided into three strands, the third of which contains case studies that exemplify content outlined in strands 1 and 2 and provide opportunities to make detailed comparisons over time.

Assessment

Students will be assessed on their knowledge and understanding, with questions focusing on similarity and difference, and change and continuity. This may include turning points (significance), extent of, and causes or consequences of change.

Historic environments

Each historic environment is linked to a thematic study and focuses on that site in its historical context. It examines the relationship between a place and historical events and developments. Much of the content is linked to the thematic study, but additionally some of the content focuses on the place itself.

Assessment

The content is assessed through a question on features of the period and also through a historical enquiry. For the historical enquiry, students will need to develop the skills necessary to analyse, evaluate and use contemporary sources to make substantiated judgements, in the context of the historical events studied. To aid teaching, the content is divided into two sections: the first covers the site in its historical context; the second covers knowledge, selection and use of sources relevant to this historic environment for enquiries.